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LegacyHive Windows User Profile Service Arbitrary Hive Load Privilege Escalation

Vulnerability Report

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LegacyHive Windows User Profile Service Arbitrary Hive Load Privilege Escalation

1. Executive Summary

LegacyHive is a publicly disclosed Windows local privilege-escalation vulnerability affecting the Windows User Profile Service, also known as ProfSvc. The public proof of concept was released by the researcher using the Nightmare-Eclipse / Chaotic Eclipse identity on 14 July 2026, shortly after Microsoft's July Patch Tuesday cycle. The disclosure is notable because the author claims the technique remains functional on all currently supported Windows desktop and server versions with July 2026 updates installed, and because the disclosed code provides defenders and capable adversaries with enough implementation detail to understand the abused primitive even though the public build is intentionally restricted.

At the time of this report, no CVE identifier, Microsoft advisory, or vendor patch dedicated to LegacyHive has been confirmed in the reviewed public sources. Public reporting consistently describes the issue as an arbitrary registry hive loading flaw in ProfSvc. The released proof of concept requires credentials for another standard user and a third target username; if successful, it causes the target user's hive to be mounted into the current user's classes-root context. The author states that the original, unreleased version did not require the additional credential and was not limited to the UsrClass.dat hive. Lost Boys Cyber assesses that the public release should be treated as a post-compromise privilege-escalation and lateral-abuse risk rather than a standalone remote compromise.

The defensive priority is containment and telemetry coverage. Organizations should restrict local interactive access, reduce unnecessary local accounts, harden workstation administrative practices, and monitor for unusual ProfSvc-driven user-profile loading, access to NTUSER.DAT and UsrClass.dat across user boundaries, suspicious object-manager symbolic link creation, and temporary root-level GUID directories used during exploitation. Because no official fix was identified during review, the control strategy should assume a temporary exposure window until Microsoft publishes authoritative remediation guidance.

Field	Assessment
Report Title	LegacyHive Windows User Profile Service Arbitrary Hive Load Privilege Escalation
Report family	Vulnerability Report
Subject	LegacyHive Windows User Profile Service arbitrary hive load privilege escalation
Disclosure status	Public proof of concept and technical details available
CVE status	No CVE confirmed in reviewed sources as of 2026-07-15 UTC
Affected technology	Microsoft Windows ProfSvc / user profile registry hive loading
Affected scope	Claimed all supported Windows desktop and server versions through July 2026 patch level
Exploitation vector	Local authenticated context; public PoC requires extra standard-user credentials
Primary impact	Unauthorized loading and potential read/write access to another user's registry hive context
Operational severity	High where adversaries can gain low-privilege interactive access; medium where endpoints are tightly controlled
Confidence	Medium-high for public PoC behavior; medium for full-impact

claims until Microsoft publishes advisory details

2. Intelligence Requirement

This report answers the following intelligence requirement: What is LegacyHive, what risk does it create for Windows environments, and what should defenders do before Microsoft publishes authoritative remediation?

The analysis focuses on practical defender outcomes rather than exploit reproduction. The reviewed evidence supports four operational questions:

Requirement	Answered by this report
Vulnerability identity	Public LegacyHive disclosure, no confirmed CVE at writing
Exploitation preconditions	Local authenticated foothold; public PoC requires a second standard-user credential and target username
Defensive exposure	Windows endpoints and servers where untrusted users or compromised accounts can run code locally
Monitoring strategy	Endpoint telemetry for profile hive access, registry user-shell-folder manipulation, object-manager link creation, temporary GUID staging directories, and unexpected ProfSvc activity

Analyst assumptions:

- The reviewed public proof of concept is not treated as a full weaponized exploit chain. It is treated as a reliable indicator of the underlying primitive and likely adversary research direction.
- No vendor patch is assumed available unless Microsoft later publishes an advisory or out-of-band update.
- Detection examples below are designed for authorized defensive monitoring and should be tuned against local endpoint telemetry before production alerting.

3. Source Review and Confidence

Lost Boys Cyber reviewed primary and secondary sources available on 15 July 2026 UTC. The original public repository provides the strongest evidence for claimed proof-of-concept behavior, while industry reporting provides useful context on affected versions, disclosure timing, researcher history, and defender urgency.

Source	Type	Key contribution	Confidence
MSNightmare / LegacyHive GitHub repository	Primary disclosure and PoC source	States the vulnerability class, public PoC constraints, arbitrary hive-load claim, and July 2026 patch compatibility	High for what the author published; medium for claims not independently validated
SecurityOnline report, 14 July 2026	Secondary vulnerability reporting	Summarizes no-CVE status, no confirmed exploitation, affected supported Windows versions, and interim mitigations	Medium
Cyber Security News report, 15 July 2026	Secondary vulnerability reporting	Describes mounted target hive under current user's classes root and recommends monitoring NTUSER.DAT / UsrClass.dat access	Medium
The Hacker News report, 15 July 2026	Secondary reporting with Microsoft-response context	Confirms ProfSvc description, public PoC preconditions, and	Medium

		Microsoft investigation status	
The Register report, 15 July 2026	Secondary reporting with practitioner commentary	Frames LegacyHive as useful post-compromise primitive; quotes practitioner assessment that fully weaponized compromise requires additional work	Medium

Confidence statement: Confidence is medium-high that LegacyHive represents a real ProfSvc/user-hive handling weakness with a functional public demonstration under constrained preconditions. Confidence is lower regarding exploitability beyond those preconditions because the author explicitly states the public PoC was reduced and Microsoft had not published a technical advisory at the time of review. Defensive recommendations are therefore framed around observable behavior and exposure reduction rather than unverified root-cause claims.

4. Key Findings

ID	Finding	Defensive implication	Confidence
F1	LegacyHive targets Windows ProfSvc handling of user registry hives and can mount another user's hive into the current user's classes-root context.	User-profile and registry-hive telemetry become critical detection sources; endpoint teams should not limit monitoring to process creation alone.	Medium-high
F2	The public PoC is constrained but not harmless: it requires another standard user's credentials and a third target username, but the author claims the original did not require additional credentials and could load arbitrary hives.	Capable actors may use the public code as a starting point to recover missing pieces or develop variants. Treat as an active research-to-weaponization risk.	Medium
F3	Public sources report no CVE, no Microsoft advisory, and no confirmed in-the-wild exploitation at the time of writing.	Patch-based remediation may not be immediately available. Compensating controls and threat hunting are required during the exposure window.	Medium-high
F4	The PoC source indicates suspicious behaviors: creation of root-level GUID directories, permissive DACLs, object-manager directory and symbolic-link manipulation, modification of User Shell Folders Local AppData, copying UsrClass.dat, opening NTUSER.DAT, and spawning a logged-on helper process.	Detection should combine file, registry, process, and advanced endpoint telemetry rather than relying on a single signature.	High for PoC-derived behavior
F5	The practical threat is post-compromise elevation or cross-user hive access, not internet-scale remote exploitation by itself.	Prioritize high-risk shared workstations, jump boxes, VDI, RDS hosts, developer machines, and servers where low-privilege local users can	Medium-high

		execute code.	
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4.1. Technical Behavior Summary

Windows stores user-specific configuration in registry hive files such as NTUSER.DAT and UsrClass.dat. ProfSvc loads and manages these hives as part of user logon/profile handling. LegacyHive abuses the service's hive-loading behavior to cause a target user's hive to be mounted into another context. Public reporting describes the result as privileged read/write access to another user's hive if exploitation is successful.

A review of the public PoC source supports the following behavior-level observations:

Behavior	Observed in public PoC source	Detection value
Uses Win32, Native API, UserEnv, Advapi32, Offline Registry APIs, and RPC UUID functions	Includes ntdll, UserEnv, AclAPI, offreg, Rpcrt4	Useful for static triage of binaries named as LegacyHive derivatives
Creates a random GUID-named directory under C:\	Work directory generated from UuidCreate and concatenated under C:\	High-signal when paired with profile-hive file activity
Applies permissive Everyone ACLs to staging directory	Explicit DACL grants GENERIC_ALL to Everyone	Useful file/ACL anomaly signal
Creates object-manager directories and symbolic links under BaseNamedObjects\Restricted	Native API calls create object directories and symbolic links targeting Windows profile paths	High-value EDR telemetry where object-manager events are available
Opens and backs up a user's NTUSER.DAT	Reads target user hive file into memory	Monitor cross-user profile hive access by unusual processes
Modifies User Shell Folders Local AppData in hive data	Sets Local AppData to \\.\globalroot\BaseNamedObjects\Restricted	Strong registry anomaly if captured before cleanup
Copies UsrClass.dat to the staging directory	CopyFile from AppData\Local\Microsoft\Windows\UsrClass.dat	Strong file telemetry signal when paired with GUID staging directory
Uses an oplock and a helper process launched with another credential	FSCTL_REQUEST_BATCH_OPLOCK and CreateProcessWithLogonW	Advanced signal for exploit timing behavior
Checks RegOpenUserClassesRoot outcome	Confirms hive loaded into user classes root	Detection value mostly through surrounding behavior
Attempts cleanup and hive restoration	Deletes staging files and removes directory	Hunting should include short-lived artifacts, not only current-state files

This report intentionally omits step-by-step exploit reproduction. The behavior above is provided to support defensive detection engineering, incident response triage, and authorized lab validation.

5. Threat Context

LegacyHive belongs to a recurring 2026 pattern of publicly disclosed Windows local privilege escalation and defense-evasion vulnerabilities released by the Nightmare-Eclipse / Chaotic Eclipse persona. Public reporting states that earlier disclosures in this series were weaponized quickly after publication, including Microsoft Defender-related issues. That history increases the urgency of defensive coverage even though LegacyHive's public PoC appears less complete than prior releases.

Local privilege escalation vulnerabilities are frequently used after phishing, credential theft, malicious software execution, or exploitation of a separate remote-facing weakness. They can convert a low-privilege foothold into access that supports credential theft, persistence, lateral movement, and security-control tampering. LegacyHive is especially sensitive because Windows registry hives can influence COM registrations, shell behavior, application launch paths, file associations, and user-

specific configuration. Even if the public PoC only demonstrates hive mounting, variants that permit arbitrary hive load or write access could become powerful building blocks inside a broader intrusion chain.

Environment	Exposure relevance	Defensive priority
Shared workstations and kiosks	Multiple local profiles increase cross-user hive-abuse opportunities	High
VDI and RDS hosts	Many user profiles and frequent logons create noisy but valuable ProfSvc telemetry	High
Administrator workstations	Hive access to privileged users may expose configuration and escalation paths	High
Developer workstations	Local admin sprawl, build tools, and credentials increase blast radius	High
Servers with interactive logon disabled	Lower direct exposure, but still relevant if attackers obtain local code execution	Medium
Consumer endpoints	Risk depends on local account model and exposure to commodity malware	Medium

5.1. MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

Technique	Name	Relevance
T1068	Exploitation for Privilege Escalation	LegacyHive is primarily a local privilege-escalation primitive after an attacker can execute code locally.
T1112	Modify Registry	The public PoC modifies registry hive content, including User Shell Folders values, as part of the profile-loading manipulation.
T1106	Native API	The PoC calls Native API routines to create object-manager directories and symbolic links.
T1059	Command and Scripting Interpreter	Not intrinsic to LegacyHive, but likely surrounding tradecraft when attackers deliver, compile, or execute a weaponized tool.
T1003	OS Credential Dumping	Not directly demonstrated by the public PoC. Included as a downstream risk if hive access is combined with credential material discovery or broader privilege escalation.
T1546.015	Event Triggered Execution: Component Object Model Hijacking	Not directly demonstrated. Included as a potential downstream risk because user-class hives may influence COM-related behavior.

6. Detection and Hunting

Detection should focus on behavior chains rather than a single file name. Public exploit derivatives can be renamed, recompiled, or embedded in another loader. Stronger coverage comes from correlating process, registry, file, and user-profile events around unusual hive access.

Detection objective	Telemetry	Example signal
Identify suspicious profile-hive file access	EDR file events, Sysmon Event ID 11/15, MDE DeviceFileEvents	Non-system process reads or copies C:\Users*\NTUSER.DAT or C:\Users*\AppData\Local\Microsoft\Windows\UsrClass.dat for a different user
Identify staging directory creation	File events, ACL-change telemetry	Short-lived C:\{GUID} directories with permissive Everyone ACLs and hive files beneath them
Identify User Shell Folders manipulation	Registry events, Sysmon Event ID 13, MDE DeviceRegistryEvents	Local AppData set to a globalroot / BaseNamedObjects path or changed shortly before ProfSvc activity
Identify helper process behavior	Process events, Windows Security 4624/4648, MDE DeviceProcessEvents	CreateProcessWithLogon-like behavior spawning benign Windows binaries in suspended or unusual context
Identify object-manager abuse	EDR advanced telemetry, kernel-object monitoring where available	Creation of BaseNamedObjects\Restricted object directories or symbolic links by a non-system process
Identify exploit cleanup patterns	File deletion and process termination events	Hive copy created and deleted in a root-level GUID directory within minutes

6.1. Microsoft Defender for Endpoint Hunting Queries

The following KQL queries are designed as starting points. Tune allowed administrative tools, backup agents, EDR products, and profile-management software before enabling alerting.

```
// Hunt: suspicious cross-user registry hive file access
let HiveNames = dynamic(["NTUSER.DAT", "UsrClass.dat"]);
DeviceFileEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(14d)
| where FileName in~ (HiveNames)
| where FolderPath has @"\Users\"
| where ActionType in~ ("FileCreated", "FileModified", "FileRenamed", "FileOpened", "FileRead", "FileCopied")
| extend ProfileUser = extract(@"\Users\[^\[]+\\", 1, FolderPath)
| where isnotempty(ProfileUser)
| where InitiatingProcessAccountName != ProfileUser
| where InitiatingProcessFileName !in~ ("svchost.exe", "lsass.exe", "explorer.exe", "SearchIndexer.exe")
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, ActionType, FolderPath, ProfileUser, InitiatingProcessFileName, InitiatingProcessCommandLine, InitiatingProcessAccountName, InitiatingProcessParentFileName, SHA256
| order by Timestamp desc

// Hunt: root-level GUID staging directories containing profile hive artifacts
DeviceFileEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(14d)
| where FolderPath matches regex @"(?:i)^C:\\[0-9a-f]{8}-[0-9a-f]{4}-[0-9a-f]{4}-[0-9a-f]{4}-[0-9a-f]{12}\\\"
| where FolderPath has_any ("NTUSER.DAT", "UsrClass.dat", "ntuser.dat")
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, ActionType, FolderPath, FileName, InitiatingProcessFileName,
```

```

InitiatingProcessCommandLine, InitiatingProcessAccountName, SHA256
| order by Timestamp desc
// Hunt: User Shell Folders Local AppData redirected to globalroot/BaseNamedObjects
DeviceRegistryEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(14d)
| where RegistryKey has @("Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Explorer\User Shell Folders"
| where RegistryValueName =~ "Local AppData"
| where RegistryValueData has_any ("globalroot", "BaseNamedObjects", "Restricted")
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, ActionType, RegistryKey, RegistryValueName, RegistryValueData,
InitiatingProcessFileName, InitiatingProcessCommandLine, InitiatingProcessAccountName
| order by Timestamp desc
// Hunt: suspicious use of secondary credentials followed by profile hive access
let SecondaryLogonProcesses =
    DeviceProcessEvents
    | where Timestamp > ago(14d)
    | where ProcessCommandLine has_any ("runas", "CreateProcessWithLogon", "LOGON_WITH_PROFILE")
    or InitiatingProcessCommandLine has_any ("runas", "CreateProcessWithLogon",
"LOGON_WITH_PROFILE")
    | project DeviceId, DeviceName, ProcTime=Timestamp, ProcessId, FileName, ProcessCommandLine,
AccountName, InitiatingProcessFileName;
let HiveAccess =
    DeviceFileEvents
    | where Timestamp > ago(14d)
    | where FileName in~ ("NTUSER.DAT", "UsrClass.dat")
    | project DeviceId, HiveTime=Timestamp, FolderPath, InitiatingProcessFileName,
InitiatingProcessAccountName;
SecondaryLogonProcesses
| join kind=innerunique HiveAccess on DeviceId
| where HiveTime between (ProcTime .. ProcTime + 10m)
| project DeviceName, ProcTime, HiveTime, FileName, ProcessCommandLine, AccountName,
FolderPath, InitiatingProcessFileName, InitiatingProcessAccountName
| order by HiveTime desc

```

6.2. Sigma Rule: Suspicious User Hive Staging and Local AppData Redirection

```

rule_title: Potential LegacyHive User Profile Hive Loading Activity
id: 6f3bb1de-legacyhive-hive-load-2026
status: experimental
description: Detects behavior associated with the public LegacyHive PoC, including root-level GUID
staging directories for user registry hives and Local AppData redirection to
globalroot/BaseNamedObjects paths.
author: Lost Boys Cyber
date: 2026-07-15
references:
- https://github.com/MSNightmare/LegacyHive
- https://thehackernews.com/2026/07/researcher-drops-new-windows-zero-day.html
logsource:
product: windows
detection:
    selection_file_staging:
        TargetFilename|re: '^C:\[0-9a-fA-F]{8}-[0-9a-fA-F]{4}-[0-9a-fA-F]{4}-[0-9a-fA-F]{4}-[0-9a-fA-F]{12}\\.*(NTUSER.DAT|UsrClass.dat|ntuser.dat)$'
    selection_registry_redirect:
        TargetObject|contains: '\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Explorer\User Shell
Folders\Local AppData'
        Details|contains|all:
            - 'globalroot'
            - 'BaseNamedObjects'
    filter_known_system:
        Image|endswith:
            - '\svchost.exe'
            - '\explorer.exe'
            - '\SearchIndexer.exe'
    condition: (selection_file_staging or selection_registry_redirect) and not filter_known_system
fields:
- UtcTime

```

- Computer
- User
- Image
- CommandLine
- TargetFilename
- TargetObject
- Details

falsepositives:

- Profile-management tools, backup agents, forensic acquisition, and endpoint management software may legitimately access user hives. Root-level GUID staging plus globalroot redirection should be uncommon and high priority.

level: high

tags:

- attack.privilege_escalation
- attack.t1068
- attack.defense_evasion
- attack.t1112

6.3. Splunk Hunt

```
index=windows (sourcetype="XmlWinEventLog:Microsoft-Windows-Sysmon/Operational" OR
sourcetype="WinEventLog:Security")
((EventCode=11 OR EventCode=15 OR EventCode=23) (TargetFilename="*\\Users\\*\\NTUSER.DAT" OR
TargetFilename="*\\Users\\*\\UsrClass.dat" OR TargetFilename="C:\\*-*-*-*\\UsrClass.dat"))
OR (EventCode=13 TargetObject="*\\Software\\Microsoft\\Windows\\CurrentVersion\\Explorer\\User Shell
Folders\\Local AppData" Details="*BaseNamedObjects*")
| eval legacyhive_signal=case(match(TargetFilename,"(?:)^C:\\\\[0-9a-f]{8}-[0-9a-f]{4}-[0-9a-f]{4}-[0-
9a-f]{4}-[0-9a-f]{12}\\\\"),"root_guid_hive_staging",
like(Details,"%BaseNamedObjects%"),"local_appdata_globalroot_redirect", like(TargetFilename,"%\\Users\\
%"),"cross_user_hive_access", true(),"other")
| table _time host user EventCode Image CommandLine TargetFilename TargetObject Details
legacyhive_signal
| sort - _time
```

6.4. Incident Triage Questions

- Which account executed the suspected binary, and did that account normally have local interactive access to the device?
- Did the process access another user's NTUSER.DAT or UsrClass.dat?
- Was a short-lived C:\\{GUID} directory created, modified, or deleted?
- Did any registry value under User Shell Folders change to a \\globalroot\\BaseNamedObjects path?
- Did ProfSvc, svchost.exe hosting ProfSvc, or a newly spawned process load or access a user hive around the same time?
- Did the suspected account subsequently access LSASS, credential stores, browser data, DPAPI material, privileged shares, or administrative tools?
- Were new COM registrations, shell extension values, Run keys, service configurations, or file associations written into the mounted hive?

7. Recommendations

Priority	Recommendation	Owner	Rationale
P0	Track Microsoft advisory and apply the first official fix or mitigation as soon as it is released.	Endpoint engineering / vulnerability management	LegacyHive appears unpatched in July 2026 public reporting. Vendor guidance should supersede interim workarounds.
P0	Disable or tightly restrict unnecessary local interactive logon for non-administrative accounts on servers, jump hosts, admin workstations, and shared systems.	Identity / endpoint engineering	The flaw is local. Reducing who can execute code locally directly reduces exploit opportunity.
P1	Reduce local account sprawl	Identity / endpoint engineering	The public PoC requires

	and remove stale local standard-user accounts.		another standard-user credential; fewer local accounts reduces the public variant's viability.
P1	Deploy the provided hunts for NTUSER.DAT / UserClass.dat cross-user access and User Shell Folders globalroot redirection.	Detection engineering / SOC	These behaviors map directly to the public PoC and provide early visibility before patch availability.
P1	Increase monitoring on shared workstations, VDI/RDS hosts, helpdesk/admin systems, and developer endpoints.	SOC / endpoint engineering	These systems have higher likelihood of multiple user hives, privileged profiles, or attacker interest.
P2	Harden local administrator usage with LAPS/Windows LAPS, just-in-time admin, credential guard, and separate admin workstations.	Identity / security architecture	Limits downstream impact if attackers combine hive access with credential or persistence techniques.
P2	Add EDR watchlists for root-level GUID staging directories, object-manager symbolic-link abuse where telemetry exists, and suspicious Offline Registry API usage.	Detection engineering	Helps catch public PoC derivatives and modified implementations.
P2	Conduct authorized lab validation only in isolated systems and record benign baseline events for tuning.	Security engineering	Validates detection coverage without risking production systems or spreading exploit code.

7.1. Temporary Compensating Controls

Until an official patch or mitigation is available, prioritize the following controls:

- Enforce least privilege for local logon rights through Group Policy and endpoint-management baselines.
- Review membership of local Users, Remote Desktop Users, Backup Operators, Helpdesk, and local Administrators groups.
- Require separate, hardened admin accounts and prohibit daily-driver browsing or email from admin workstations.
- Monitor for successful and failed use of alternate credentials on endpoints, including Event ID 4648 where available.
- Alert on unexpected access to another user's profile hive files by non-system processes.
- Preserve forensic evidence quickly during investigation; the public PoC attempts cleanup and can leave short-lived artifacts.

7.2. Validation Plan

Defenders should validate coverage in a controlled lab without running untrusted code in production:

Step	Validation objective	Evidence to collect
1	Baseline normal profile loading and login behavior	ProfSvc events, hive file access, process tree, registry events
2	Simulate benign hive-file access with approved forensic tooling	Confirm detections do not over-alert on known tools after allowlisting

3	Monitor for root-level GUID directory creation and deletion	Confirm file telemetry captures short-lived staging artifacts
4	Simulate suspicious Local AppData redirection to a nonstandard path in a lab hive	Confirm registry detection logic triggers and records process context
5	Correlate process, registry, and file timelines	Validate SOC runbook can reconstruct sequence and escalation risk

8. References

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